

Northern Pike

Esox lucius

Light spots, sharp teeth, weed-edge ambush

Recognize it

Long green predator with pale oval spots on a darker body and rounded tail lobes.

Body	Cheek fully scaled, lower half of gill cover unscaled; five jaw pores per side.
Mouth/fins	Duckbill snout with backward teeth; dorsal and anal fins far back.
Confusion	Musky usually has dark marks on light body, pointed tail, and six to nine jaw pores.

Lake role

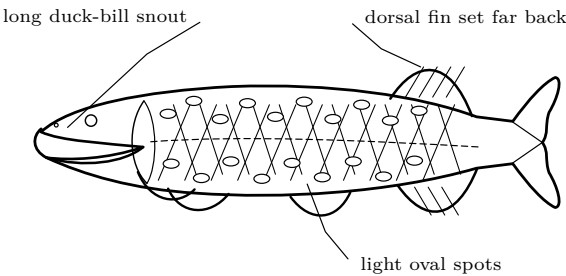
Where it belongs

Weed edges, points, current seams, and cooler deep structure in summer.

Food and season

Fish predator; early shallow vegetation, then follows prey and tolerable temperature.

Identification plate



Find it on these waters

Pine	Test spring vegetation and later the deep, cool outside weed edge rather than hot shallows.
North	Test weed walls, narrows, and inlet/outlet current with open water beside cover.
Evidence	The DNR lake records sometimes name only a broad group such as panfish. In that case this species is a candidate member, not verified individual presence. Confirm presence before targeting; treat locations as testable habitat hypotheses, not abundance findings.

Presentations

1. **Spoon or swimbait.** Run parallel to the edge; add pauses while retaining contact above vegetation.
2. **Quick-strike live bait.** Where lawful, use a leader and immediate-set two-hook rig to prevent deep hooking.
3. **Stop rule.** If water is very warm or the fish cannot be landed promptly, target another species.

HANDLING DECIDES THE OUTCOME

Use leader, net, long pliers, and cutters. Keep fingers out of mouth and gills; support fish horizontally.

Water-specific rule	May 2, 2026–Mar 7, 2027; 26-in minimum; daily bag 2 on both lakes.
Kitchen choice	A legal lower-end fish is preferable to a large breeder; use the five-piece Y-bone method.
Before the trip	Open the Wisconsin DNR water-specific regulation page for WBIC 779200 (Pine) or 850800 (North). Check the exact water, species, and date; the live rule controls if this dated sheet differs.

Keep only a fish you can use

Decide before the cast. Bring ice, stop fishing when the planned meal is secured, and use the species-specific cooking guide for dispatch, bone layout, and safe preparation. Large old predators are valuable spawners and generally carry more mercury than smaller fish.

Sources checked 2026-07-26. Wisconsin DNR lake fish records (Pine WBIC 779200; North WBIC 850800), Wisconsin’s Fishes, Hook Your Catch, 2026–27 water-specific regulations, Catch-and-release Guidelines, and Eating Your Catch. Biological and tactical synthesis is editorial; it is not a current population survey.

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